

IE 8 = longer battery life?

A recent test shows that Internet Explorer 8 provides more laptop battery time than Firefox, Chrome, and other browsers



ARM processors scales 2 GHz

ARMs Cortex A-9 scales to 2 GHz, meaning we could well be seeing them in the desktop processor sphere

Laptop test

Dell Studio XPS 1340 Guts n Glory

The Studio XPS 1340 goes the way of its larger sibling complete with leather accents on the bottom of the lid. It's distinctly upmarket looking and feels very solid while retaining a semblance of compactness. The top bezel is rather wide and although it integrates a webcam, the lid mechanism is really sturdy. The glossy black has a translucent look to it and in places it is where embedded LEDs indicate touch buttons just above the keypad. The keypad itself is well laid out with large keys and although not segregated in the truest sense the edges of the keys are slightly lower creating the impression of a gap. The keys are comfortable to type on and feedback is signature Dell – slightly soft and on the mushy side, but key travel is good and overall usable. People liking the firm feedback on the Acer notebooks will be disappointed but it's just a different design nothing good or bad about it. The trackpad is responsive but not as exact as we'd like and its small size is no help. In fact the trackpad is a grouse because after an hour of use one begins to miss a USB mouse – a sure sign of a less than perfect trackpad. Trackpad buttons are good – mushy with good key travel and comfortable – a relief from clicky-clacky mouse buttons.

In terms of performance the XPS 1340 has got what it takes to trail with the best. The GPU isn't particularly powerful but it's more than sufficient for even casual gamers. Priced at Rs. 59,900 (configuration dependent of course) the Studio XPS 1340 is a great mix of style and

performance. It's also portable enough to be lugged around anywhere and it's easy on the eye – the proverbial icing on the cake.

ASUS U6 Bamboo When wood is good

ASUS' U6 series represent their efforts at extreme portability with good performance. The Bamboo is a special edition notebook livered in (you guessed it!) Bamboo. The lid is covered in the wood as is the palmrest and the trackpad. The rest of the notebook is grey/silver and looks quite exclusive as a result. The keys are spaced out but not segregated, similar to the design used on the previous generation of Dell notebooks like the XPS M1330. Keypad feedback and usability is good and the U6 has a pretty responsive trackpad although its texture is not good as it tends to grip your finger pad owing to the varnished surface. The right side of the keypad feels a little cramped with tiny *Enter* and *Shift* keys. Like the Vaio Z48GD the mode switch toggles between integrated Intel graphics and a GeForce 9300M.

The U6 Bamboo is priced at Rs. 98,990, and this includes a two-year, worldwide warranty from ASUS. We reckon this is Rs. 15,000 more than we'd like for something with this configuration although to be honest there's a lot of uniqueness to the look.

Acer Aspire 3810T A sweet deal

The 3810T looks decidedly upmarket with its slim profile and brushed aluminium lid. Since it's smaller than the 5810T it looks thicker, but the thickness of both notebooks is the same. It feels extremely well built in hand and the body is clearly well constructed. The lid closes with a definitive snap. The long power button with embedded LED is stylish, so is the silver/grey body. The keypad is really sweet with great spacing, very nice key feedback – ultra usable and very comfortable, the keypad just feels right. The screen



resolution is just right for a 13.3-inch display – 1366 x 768 pixels. Brightness levels are good but the colour quality is very ordinary. The touch based keys atop the keypad work well and we like the minimalist styling. The battery indicator is located on the front, just below the trackpad and its bright orange LED is distinctly visible but not obtrusive.

Performance wise there's not much grunt under the hood so we didn't expect much, but this notebook isn't about performance. It's about style, portability and usability and it meets these parameters in spades. Quite frankly a price tag of Rs. 31,999 is pretty amazing – if you're looking for value for money – you've got it! Our only grouse is Acer overlooked an optical drive – a shame because this would be a killer product with one. Sans that however, it still manages to bag our *Best Buy* award and we feel it's well deserved. Should you want something good enough for most mundane tasks that is also compact buying this is a no-brainer. The battery life is an amazing 328 minutes.

ASUS UX30 Lots of show, little go

ASUS' UX30 is their compact, low power offering. It's innards are similar to the Aspire 3810T. It's a lot flashier looking however, with a piano black finish reminiscent of some LCD HDTVs. It also borrows the idea of enclosing connectors with a small slider door from the Macbook Air. The lid is brushed aluminium and so is the palmrest. ASUS chose to use the same trackpads that the K40J and K50J use – ugh! The keypad has good feedback but usability is not as good owing to a mediocre layout that doesn't feel intuitive

at first use. The 14-inch display is also pretty mediocre, despite the LED-backlighting. One plus is the enormous hard drive – ASUS thought it prudent to load the UX30 with 500 GB worth of storage. Its price was a little over the top at Rs. 56,000 and we cannot see anyone spending this much. Not when the Aspire 3810T gives more for less. If we were up to blowing close to 60 grand on a notebook we'd figure the Dell Studio XPS 1340 would get a nod over this in anyone's books.

MSI X400 When ignorance is bliss

MSI also joins the bandwagon of people offering compact notebooks based on Intel's U series of Core Solo processors. In general the effort is proportionate to the applause and we're not cheering much. The X400 is



compact, but it's not well built. The body feels like cheap plastic and the notebooks exterior was a let down. Inside the textured palmrest also feels cheap – really this is unforgivable and we're trying to see something good. The keypad is also tacky, added to this the keys aren't well laid out. Key spacing feels slightly off owing to the large keys and this is not intuitive to most peoples' fingers, who will be used to closer key alignments. There's nothing much to write



ASUS UX30

home about here and about all that we can say that the MSI X400 is a first effort, and better things are sure to come out of the mistakes made this round. At Rs. 40,000 its one notebook you can easily afford to miss.

BEST BUY
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OCTOBER 2009



Dell Studio XPS 1340



Acer Aspire 3810T